
title: "Overview & Introduction: Why This Moment Matters"
subtitle: "A Message to the BankUnited Team"
short_title: "Introduction"
description: "An introduction to the AI master class designed specifically for BankUnited professionals, setting the stage for transformative learning."
label: ch-00-introduction
tags: [introduction, AI, BankUnited, Microsoft Copilot, overview]

Overview & Introduction: Why This Moment Matters

:::{figure} ../images/ch00-intro-infographic.png
:label: fig-ch00-infographic
:alt: Illustrated overview of AI transformation in banking, showing a journey from traditional workflows to AI-augmented excellence
:width: 80%
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The AI transformation journey — from curiosity to mastery. This master class is your roadmap.
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"The illiterate of the 21st century will not be those who cannot read and write, but those who cannot learn, unlearn, and relearn."
— Alvin Toffler

There are rare moments in history when a new technology doesn't just improve how we work — it fundamentally redefines what work means. The steam engine ended the era of manual labor as the primary source of economic power. The internet collapsed the cost of information to near zero. Artificial intelligence, and specifically the large language model revolution we are living through right now, is doing something arguably more profound: it is democratizing *cognitive leverage*.

For the first time in history, every professional at every level of an organization has access to something that used to be reserved for the most elite: an infinitely patient, extraordinarily well-read thinking partner available around the clock, at zero marginal cost, with expertise spanning law, finance, medicine, technology, communication, data analysis, and virtually every other domain of human knowledge. That thinking partner is already sitting inside your Microsoft 365 account. It is called Copilot.

This book is your master class for understanding it, using it, and — most importantly — thinking with it.

Why BankUnited? Why Now?

BankUnited is not just a bank. It is a story of resilience, vision, and excellence that South Florida should be proud of. Founded in its modern form in 2009 from the ashes of the financial crisis, BankUnited was rebuilt from the ground up by visionary leaders who believed that a

bank could be simultaneously performance-driven and deeply client-centric. Under the steady leadership of President and CEO **Rajinder Singh** — who has been a guiding force since the bank's very founding in 2009 and who took the CEO role in 2017 — BankUnited has grown into the **largest independent depository institution headquartered in the state of Florida**, with over **\$35 billion in assets**, **\$29.4 billion in deposits**, and a footprint that spans Florida, New York, Texas, Georgia, New Jersey, and North Carolina.

That trajectory is not accidental. It reflects a culture of *committed excellence* — a phrase BankUnited lives by. In 2025, Newsweek named BankUnited one of **America's Most Trustworthy Companies**, a distinction earned not by marketing but by behavior repeated thousands of times across 55 banking centers and countless client interactions. The South Florida Business Journal has consistently ranked BankUnited as the **#1 South Florida community bank by assets** — year after year.

Organizations at this level of performance don't rest on past success. They look ahead. They identify what's coming before it arrives. And what is coming — what is already here — is the AI transformation of financial services.

The question is not whether AI will reshape banking. It already has. The question is whether the professionals inside BankUnited will shape *how* that transformation happens, or whether they will watch from the sidelines while the opportunity passes them by.

This master class says: you will not watch. You will lead.

What This Book Is

Think of this as a TED talk you can read. We are not going to burden you with academic jargon or lengthy technical treatises. We are going to answer the questions that actually matter to you, as a banking professional:

- **What exactly is AI?** Not the science fiction version. The real version. And what can it actually do?
- **What is Microsoft Copilot and how does it work inside your daily tools?**
- **How do I use it to become measurably better at my job?**
- **What are the rules, risks, and responsibilities that a professional like you needs to understand?**
- **How do I move from simply using AI to genuinely *thinking with AI*?**

This book won't just give you knowledge. It will give you a new *relationship* with thinking itself.

The Arvin Ash Principle

There is a science communicator on YouTube named Arvin Ash whose channel has captivated millions of people with a seemingly simple approach: take the most complex ideas in physics, mathematics, and technology, and explain them using *nothing but analogies and curiosity*. No unnecessary jargon. No condescension. No hand-waving. Just the real concept, explained so clearly that you can share it with someone at dinner that same night.

That is the operating principle of this book.

Every concept we cover — from Large Language Models to context windows to AI agents — will be explained the way Arvin would explain it: starting with something you already know, building a bridge to the new idea, and then revealing the implications that should genuinely

surprise you. Because they should. The implications of what you are about to learn are genuinely astonishing.

How to Use This Book

This is a **hands-on master class**. Every chapter includes "Try This" exercises that take you directly into your Microsoft 365 environment and have you interact with Copilot in real time. The exercises are not optional homework. They are the actual learning. Reading about a bicycle and riding a bicycle are entirely different experiences.

You will need:

- A Microsoft 365 account with Copilot enabled (check with your IT administrator)
- Access to [m365.cloud.microsoft \(https://m365.cloud.microsoft\)](https://m365.cloud.microsoft) — this is your front door to Enterprise Copilot
- About 15 minutes of focused time per chapter for the exercises

No prior technical knowledge is required. If you can write an email, you can learn to use AI.

A Note on Voice

This book will speak to you directly. We will use "you" throughout because this transformation is personal. What AI does for your career, your productivity, and your value inside BankUnited is determined by what *you* choose to do with it. The tools are neutral. The results are up to you.

One more thing before we begin. There is a quiet revolution happening in how people interact with AI that we want to put in front of you early. Tools like **Wispr Flow** and **Super Whisper** allow you to speak to your computer — to your AI — the same way you would speak to a colleague. Instead of typing out your prompts, you simply *talk*. Your words are transcribed and sent to Copilot in real time. People who adopt voice-first AI interaction report that their outputs are dramatically better: more natural, more nuanced, more complete. The reason is simple — we speak far faster than we type, and we explain things more naturally in speech than in writing.

Before this program is over, we want you to try it. You may never go back.

What's Ahead

In **Chapter 1: The Essentials**, we build your complete conceptual foundation. You will understand what a Large Language Model actually is, how tokens work, what context engineering means and why it is the most valuable skill in the AI era, how to set your AI's persona, how to communicate with AI like an expert (meta-prompting), how your data is already connected to Copilot, and what an AI agent is and how to build your first one.

By the time you finish Chapter 1, you will not just *know about* AI. You will have used it in ways that are directly relevant to your work at BankUnited. You will have seen it respond to your email, your calendar, your business data. You will have built something.

Let's get started. The room is waiting.

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For the BankUnited Team

Everything in this book has been designed with your specific context in mind. The examples, exercises, and use cases reflect the realities of commercial banking, relationship management, operations, compliance, and executive leadership. When you see a scenario in these pages, you should recognize it. This is your world, viewed through the lens of what AI makes possible.

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